A neighbourhood opens to its harbour.

A neighbourhood opens gradually to its harbour: familiar streets lead to shared gardens, gardens rise into a local market, and the market releases into an open timber pier. Density belongs where it can sustain everyday services; the waterfront belongs to public life.

01 / Belong to Charleston

Context → neighbourhood

Union Pier begins with the streets around it. Ansonborough informs the western sequence of brick, piazza and garden; the southern quarter draws on the passages and layered commercial life of the French Quarter. Contemporary civic buildings give the new district its own addresses and skyline.

02 / Make density useful

Neighbourhood → shared court

Useful density brings homes, work and everyday services together. Fine-grained residential frontages enclose shared courts. Sculpted cultural buildings, terraced hotels and a daylit museum establish distinct public addresses, with generous entrances at the scale of the street.

03 / Choose how to walk

Street → garden → market

A direct route makes daily trips legible. Alongside it, curved garden walks reveal successive trees, courts and glimpses of the harbour. The invitation to linger comes from changing spaces and useful destinations; people can always choose a clear, shorter way through.

04 / Trade beneath a shared roof

Market court → raised terrace

The market is a family of iron-and-glass halls: six larger garden halls and twelve smaller, individually rotated halls clustered towards the pier. La Boqueria informs the exposed trusses, coloured entrance glazing and visible stalls. Translucent roofs sit over open aisles; garden paths reach all eighteen halls. The heavier programme remains inside the Battery interface, with a public pier beyond.

05 / Open the edge to ordinary life

Terrace → pier → harbour

Beyond the heavier landward buildings, a timber pier on piles becomes a sequence of open rooms: shaded pavilions, activity courts, fishing and viewing terraces, and five harbour cutouts. Rain courts change the experience after a storm. The public edge welcomes residents as well as visitors.

06 / Let the district change

Everyday life → long-term care

The plan needs an operating life as well as a physical form. Shared courts can host small events; open pavilions accommodate changing uses. Local tenancy, public access, maintenance and ecological care become design decisions with named responsibilities, rather than promises attached to a rendering.

Informed by David Sim, Soft City: Building Density for Everyday Life (Island Press, 2019), using published author excerpts at Gehl. The following checks are our project-specific interpretation, not a certification or a complete book summary.

Ask. Draw. Measure. Revise.

SC01 / Varied buildings, coherent streets

Modelled / programme unresolved

Does density create useful proximity without a monotonous street wall?

Retain residential address rhythms and differentiate six civic, hotel and port landmarks with sculpted roof forms and terraces.

Evidence

189 retained district bodies, six landmark bodies and eighteen covered market halls. The pier-facing row doubles from six to twelve smaller halls.

Next check

Confirm entrance locations, household mix and ground-floor tenancy.

SC02 / A choice of outdoor rooms

Modelled / use and comfort to test

Can people find different spaces for quiet, play, meeting and looking out?

Two major lawns, shared courts, heritage forecourt, market courts, five harbour cutouts, two activity courts and six shade pavilions.

Evidence

Five cutouts and two sports surfaces are explicit geometry; sports markings are conceptual, not regulation certification.

Next check

Add seating schedules and test noisy/quiet adjacencies.

SC03 / Spaces that can change use

Design intent / not yet tested

Can buildings and public spaces adapt through a day and over years?

Open market halls with visible stalls, partial rear-row mezzanines and independent roof frames offer different occupation scales. Open pier pavilions remain available for public activity.

Evidence

Stall counters, roof frames and concept mezzanines are modelled. Trader leases, fit-out services, structure and escape arrangements are unresolved.

Next check

Draw one typical hall plan and one event-day operating plan.

Status describes evidence maturity. No numerical pass mark is borrowed from Soft City. Technical feasibility requires separate access, fire, structural, coastal and drainage review.

Ask. Draw. Measure. Revise.

SC04 / Comfort at the threshold

Partly modelled

Does a person encounter a door, shade and a place to pause rather than a blank edge?

Charleston galleries meet expressive civic entrances, open market aisles and transparent pitched roofs.

Evidence

Thirty market entrance connections are explicit geometry; residential door and seating schedules remain to develop.

Next check

Develop representative street sections and an entrance inventory.

SC05 / A direct walk and a slower choice

Geometry checked / access review open

Can everyone understand and complete the route without being forced into a detour?

Keep direct contour walks; add garden meanders, pier loops and four broad crossings. Route one service lane smoothly onto the pier.

Evidence

Eighteen halls connect to the garden walk through thirty entrance paths. Sampled branch centreline grades stay below 4.58%; the service road remains about 454 m long, 4.2 m wide and at most 2.65% on its sampled centreline. Crossfall and whole-route continuity are not yet certified.

Next check

Audit the complete step-free network and track the nominated emergency/service vehicles.

SC06 / Belonging and public access

Spatial intent / governance open

Can residents recognise their addresses and use the waterfront without becoming customers?

Retain the Bennett Rice Mill facade; connect it to a contemporary gateway and public parks. Keep the waterfront route outside ticketed or commercial premises.

Evidence

Heritage and new gateway are modelled; public-access rights and affordable tenancy are not established.

Next check

Create an ownership/access brief and local-business allocation strategy.

Status describes evidence maturity. No numerical pass mark is borrowed from Soft City. Technical feasibility requires separate access, fire, structural, coastal and drainage review.

Ask. Draw. Measure. Revise.

SC07 / Shade and weather choices

Requires new simulation

Is outdoor life comfortable in summer sun, rain and harbour winds?

Combine tree canopies, galleries and six open pier shade roofs; offer sheltered and exposed spaces.

Evidence

The current roofs, massing and tree locations supersede revision D ray-test percentages. Transparent glazing cannot be treated as opaque shade.

Next check

Rerun solar and comfort tests on revision G, including glazing transmission, glare, shading and ventilation.

SC08 / Use resources with care

Hypothesis / quantities required

Can the urban layout reduce material and travel demand?

Keep heavier bazaar buildings landward, limit enclosed pier mass, reuse a consistent material family and connect everyday uses on foot.

Evidence

Material names are coordinated; there is no embodied-carbon calculation or verified modal shift.

Next check

Quantify the pile/deck/parking structure and compare alternatives before claiming carbon savings.

SC09 / Living landscape and water

Geometry present / ecology and hydraulics open

Does the landscape support habitat and manage rain as a connected system?

Link the two lawns with a planted rise; add varied garden spaces and keep rain courts distinct from harbour cutouts.

Evidence

Tree instances and terrain are schematic. Species diversity, soil volumes, runoff and floodwall performance are not resolved.

Next check

Develop planting and drainage sections with ecological and coastal specialists.

Status describes evidence maturity. No numerical pass mark is borrowed from Soft City. Technical feasibility requires separate access, fire, structural, coastal and drainage review.

A neighbourhood meets the harbour.

Figure-ground / Built footprints and open ground



- Buildings / covered market
- Retained context footprint
- Open ground / courtyards
- Harbour / cutouts

Read the spaces between buildings.

The figure-ground preserves courtyard openings and distinguishes the proposal from the retained context. Open markets are shown by their covered footprint. The six separate pier shade pavilions are excluded here.

Evidence boundary

This is the current model plan, not a historical before-plan or a city survey. It must not be paired with an old proposal and labelled pre-development.

MODEL COORDINATES / +Y NORTH AS CONFIRMED BY DESIGNER / ACADEMIC PROPOSAL

2 NOV 2026 · Geometry-based study; context uses and legal site boundary are not verified.

Different uses, shared daily life.

Building-by-building proposed programme / Context occupancy remains unverified



- Neighbourhood housing
- Apartments
- Mixed use
- Waterfront market
- Hotels
- Culture
- Civic
- Heritage
- Context use unverified

Programme is a design commitment.

The colour describes an intended use. Homes, shop sizes, tenure, employment and daily services need a separate schedule; a coloured mass does not establish those outcomes.

Archived land-use study

The original UP_BuildingUse.ai is preserved beside the project sources. Its historic classifications can be reviewed separately; they have not been presented as verified 2026 occupation.

MODEL COORDINATES / +Y NORTH AS CONFIRMED BY DESIGNER / ACADEMIC PROPOSAL

2 NOV 2026 · Geometry-based study; context uses and legal site boundary are not verified.

The market releases into an open pier.

Site plan / Eighteen landward halls, five harbour cutouts, six open shade pavilions



- Garden landform
- Fixed inner terrace
- Open timber pier
- Shade roof
- Activity surface
- Separate rain courts
- Service route

A lighter waterfront

Large enclosed bazaar buildings sit landward of x=176 m in model coordinates. The outer pier carries open pavilions and recreation. Piles are conceptual supports, not engineered member sizes.

Six distinct landmarks

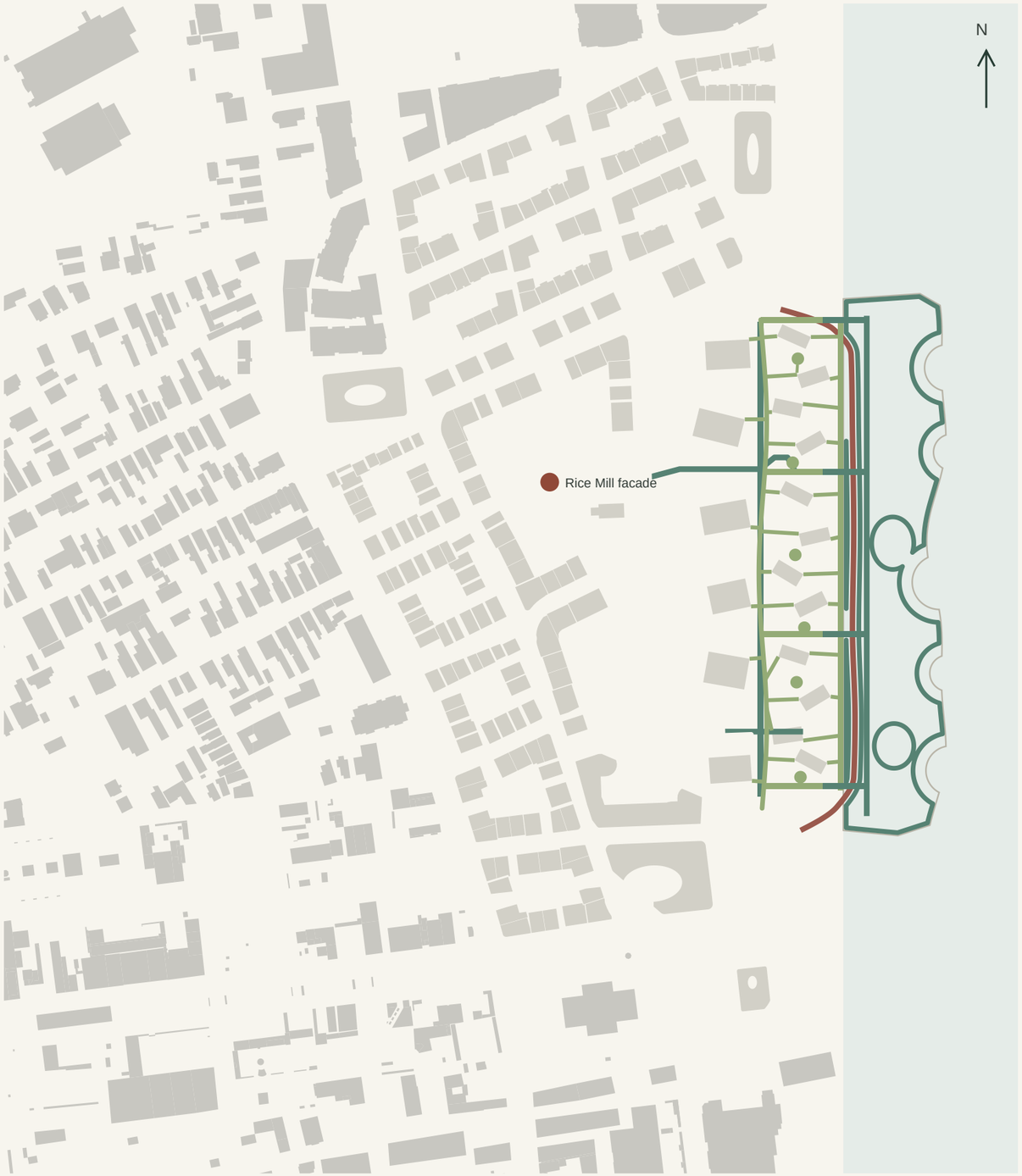
Two community centres, two hotels, a port pavilion and the maritime visitor centre use continuous sculpted bodies and terraced volumes. Residential quarters retain their finer grain.

MODEL COORDINATES / +Y NORTH AS CONFIRMED BY DESIGNER / ACADEMIC PROPOSAL

2 NOV 2026 · Geometry-based study; context uses and legal site boundary are not verified.

A direct route. A slower invitation.

Movement study / Walking choice and a single service route



- Direct / pier public walk
- Garden meander
- Single upper service route

Geometry checks

4.2 m service lane; approximately 454 m centreline; maximum sampled centreline grade 2.65%. Four broad crossing locations connect the two deck levels. Eight limited upper service bays. All 18 market halls have entrance paths; local branch centreline grades are below 4.58%.

Feasibility remains conditional

Crossfall, step-free continuity, route legibility, delivery management and emergency swept paths still require a coordinated test. Gentle road grades alone do not establish accessible or fire-safe design.

MODEL COORDINATES / +Y NORTH AS CONFIRMED BY DESIGNER / ACADEMIC PROPOSAL

2 NOV 2026 · Geometry-based study; context uses and legal site boundary are not verified.

From courtyard to harbour.

Massing sections / 1:2000 at A3; equal horizontal and vertical scale

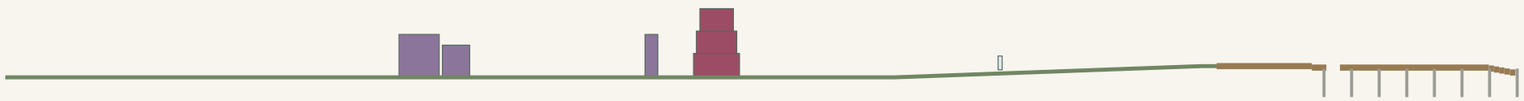
A–A / northern market and community centre



GROUND DATUM +4.42 m / INNER TERRACE +8.08 m / PIER +7.60 m

Local model levels; not a surveyed tidal or flood datum. Section cut y=90 m.

B–B / garden hotel and southern market



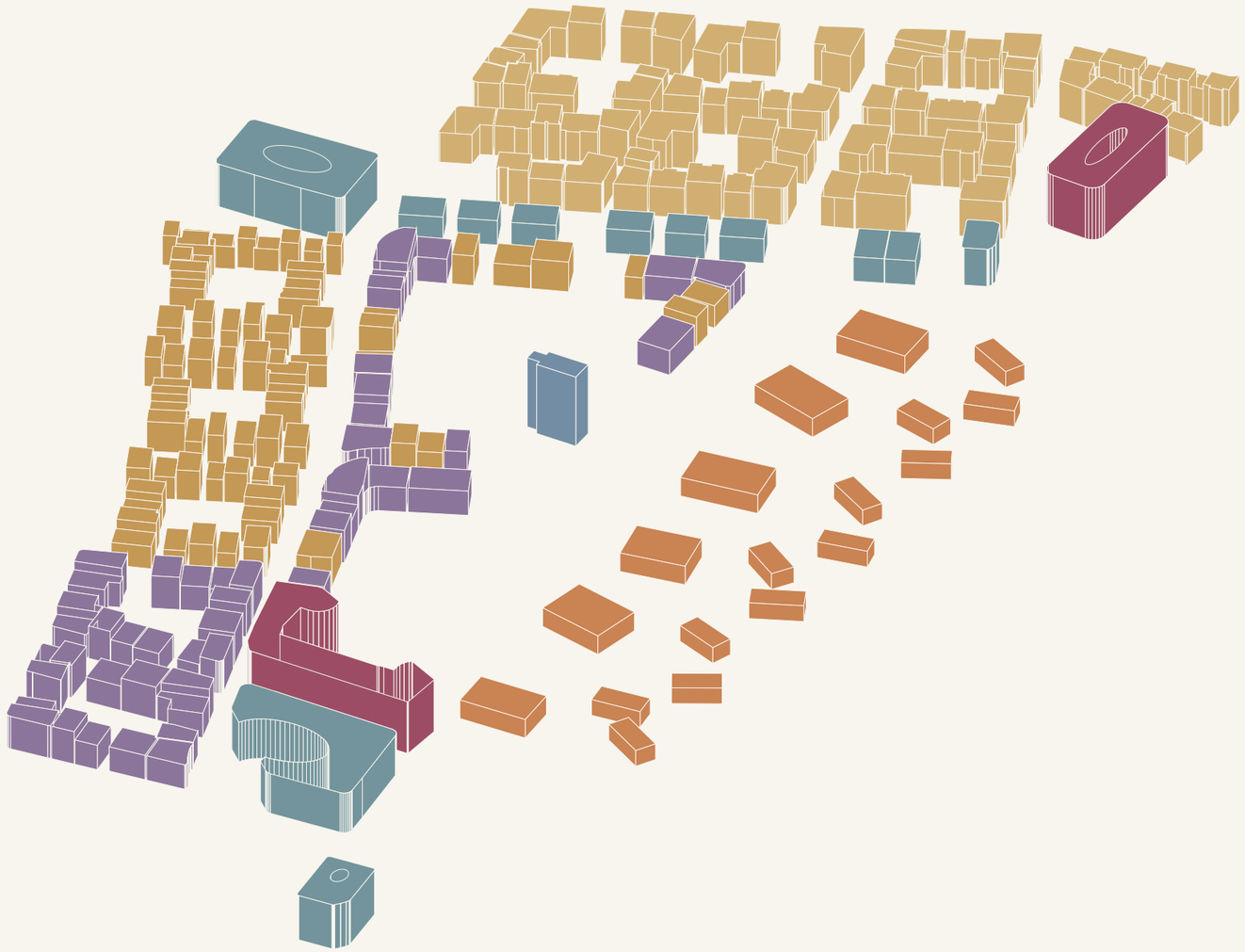
GROUND DATUM +4.42 m / INNER TERRACE +8.08 m / PIER +7.60 m

Local model levels; not a surveyed tidal or flood datum. Section cut y=-220 m.

These are envelope sections: footprint cuts are exact; sculpted roof profiles are interpolated from model vertices. Structure, rainwater flow, protective wall continuity and foundation design remain unresolved. Pier elevations and pile lengths are schematic.

Landmarks within a finer urban grain.

Orthographic massing axonometric / Envelope study, without facade detail



One city, several identities.

Residential addresses hold the ordinary street. Modern community, hotel and port buildings form a recognisable civic sequence. Covered market halls stop at the landward interface.

This drawing is an abstract envelope study generated from the same footprint and height schedule used for the Rhino revision. Use native Rhino views for facade and roof details.

MODEL COORDINATES / +Y NORTH AS CONFIRMED BY DESIGNER / ACADEMIC PROPOSAL

2 NOV 2026 · Geometry-based study; context uses and legal site boundary are not verified.